

GREAT IDEAS

GREAT MINDS

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A first class response to terrorism cannot co-exist with a **THIRD CLASS** policing system

The principal strategic challenge in any conflict comprises four elements: a realistic and accurate assessment of the threat; an objective assessment of the resources for an adequate, if not overwhelming, response (including institutional, financial, manpower and technological components); the acquisition of these resources within timeframes imposed by the conflict; and the sagacious deployment of these resources to secure the objectives of a coherent and clearly defined strategy. As legendary Chinese general Sun Tzu says, "A skilled commander seeks victory from the situation and does not demand it of his subordinates."

The *situation of victory* against terrorism has not yet been created in India.

Indeed, the very first step in the envisaged four-stage strategic process is yet to be secured. There is no consensus whatsoever, even on the nature and magnitude of the threat of terrorism in this country, and even less of an understanding of the extraordinary geopolitical environment within which this threat is being articulated.

We have, consequently, an utterly directionless and ill-informed policy discourse on the subject, a pervasive incapacity to distinguish between variables that are relevant and meaningful, and others that are mere 'noise', often imported into the discourse through political correctness, or even injected therein by advocates of the very terrorist organisations, their support structures and sponsoring states, that counter-terrorism policy is intended to confront and neutralise.

Concealed behind the dust of this enveloping confusion is a policy establishment that has atrophied over decades, and a security estab-

Trapped in the past:
The Indian security apparatus dates back to the early 20th century

